



Shylock

Portia

POUND OF FLESH

In *The Merchant of Venice*, Shylock, a moneylender, goes to court claiming that the merchant Antonio owes him a pound of flesh for failing to repay a debt. Portia, the heroine, disguises herself as a lawyer to defend Antonio. She argues that Shylock is entitled to Antonio's flesh, but not to one drop of blood.

"FOOL I' THE FOREST"

The heroine of *As You Like It* is Rosalind, one of many characters who are banished from court and go to live in the Forest of Arden. Another is Jaques, a melancholy lord who hates society and life in our "miserable world." But he enjoys talking to Rosalind's jester, Touchstone, who shares his upside-down view of the world.



Jaques



Touchstone



VALENTINE'S DAY

Valentine, the hero of *Two Gentlemen of Verona*, is exiled from Milan because he loves the Duke's daughter. He is captured by outlaws in the woods, and they are so impressed by his gentlemanly behavior that they ask him to become their leader. The play ends with Valentine finding love and winning a pardon for his outlaw friends.

Shakespeare's comedies

IN SHAKESPEARE'S TIME, a comedy simply meant a light-hearted play with a happy ending. In the 1590s, Shakespeare wrote 10 comedies, most of them with plots taken from old love stories. He liked stories in which young lovers overcome various obstacles, such as disapproving parents or comical misunderstandings, before they are allowed to marry.

The lovers might have to go on a journey, put on a disguise, or run away from home into the woods.

But everything always turns out all right in the end. *Two Gentlemen of Verona*, for example, ends in preparations for a double wedding. Valentine says to his friend Proteus, "Our day of marriage shall be yours; one feast, one house, one mutual happiness."

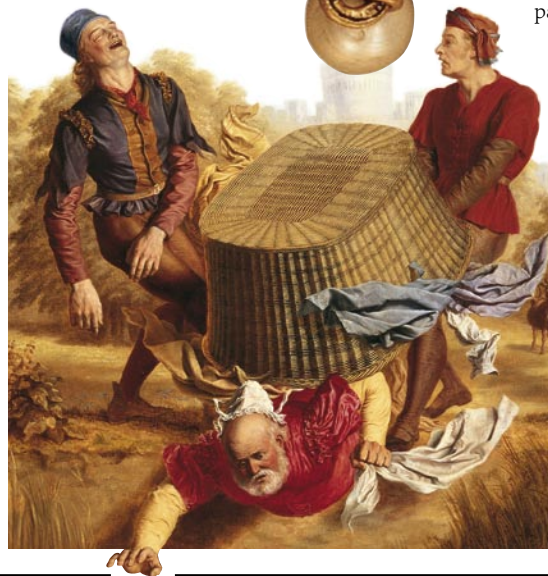


LOVE AND MARRIAGE

These portraits may have been mounted in a locket to celebrate the couple's marriage. Although people were fascinated by love stories, in real life they rarely married for love. The upper classes in particular usually married for money, or to improve their social rank.

When the locket is closed, the lovers are face to face, as if kissing

16th-century locket containing miniatures painted by Nicholas Hilliard



DITCHED

Falstaff, the old rascal from the history plays, reappears in *The Merry Wives of Windsor*. He sends love letters to two "merry wives," hoping to get hold of their money. The wives learn that he has sent the same letter to each of them and plot revenge. In one scene, Falstaff hides in a basket of dirty laundry and is then dumped in a muddy ditch.